

DOCUMENTATION · V1.0.1

# SYNODE

## Σύνοδος

*Design system, CSS architecture and elegance review for the synode.space parallax photography landing page.*

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*Style guide: Hellenic Manuscript & Classical Serif*

*Files: index.html · css/site.css · css/layout.css · js/parallax.js*

*6 October 2026*

Synode is a single-scroll fashion photography journal for *synode.space*. There is no main menu: the page reads top to bottom like a manuscript, in seven movements. Depth comes from slow parallax on photographs, sticky captions that hold while plates drift past, and stacked leaves that settle over one another. Everything else is restraint: parchment ground, ink type, hairline gold rules and one rust accent.

PAGE SEQUENCE

| #   | SECTION                                          | TECHNIQUE                                                | CLASS      |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| I   | Hero — title inscription over a full-bleed plate | Two-layer parallax: plate 0.35 down, inscription 0.12 up | .hero      |
| II  | Prologue — wide-margin text with drop cap        | Asymmetric folio grid, reveal on enter                   | .folio     |
| III | Chapter I · Aegean                               | Sticky caption column + plates drifting at ±0.05–0.08    | .chapter   |
| IV  | Interlude — inscription band                     | Full-bleed parallax background, 0.2                      | .interlude |
| V   | Chapter II · Terracotta                          | CSS sticky stacked leaves, offset like folio pages       | .stack     |
| VI  | Chapter III · Laurel                             | Asymmetric 12-column contact sheet                       | .gallery   |
| VII | Colophon — contact, return to top                | Static dark ground                                       | .colophon  |

FILE STRUCTURE

|                        |                                                                       |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| index.html             | single page, semantic sections, no <nav>                              |
| css/site.css           | tokens, base, typography, ornament, components, reveal                |
| css/layout.css         | hero, folio, chapter, interlude, stack, gallery, colophon, responsive |
| js/parallax.js         | ~70 lines, no dependencies: parallax offsets + reveal                 |
| docs/src/              | this document's source (HTML) and build script                        |
| docs/synode-v1.0.1.pdf | this document                                                         |

Load order is `site.css` then `layout.css`: layout consumes the tokens declared in site.

## 2 · CSS styling summary

COLOUR TOKENS

| TOKEN                                                                                                               | HEX     | ROLE                                              | SHARE |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|---------------------------------------------------|-------|
|  <code>--parchment-marble</code> | #F7F4EE | Page canvas                                       | 60%   |
|  <code>--aegean-ink</code>       | #0C1821 | Type; hero, interlude, colophon grounds           | 30%   |
|  <code>--amphora-rust</code>     | #A34828 | Drop caps, eyebrows, plate numbers, button, focus | 10%   |
|  <code>--hellenic-gold</code>    | #C29B38 | 1px rules at 0.4 opacity; text only on ink        |       |
|  <code>--laurel-leaf</code>      | #516053 | Captions, meta, secondary notes                   | —     |
|  <code>--thera-white</code>      | #FFFFFF | Stacked leaf cards, button text                   | —     |

Semantic aliases (`--color-bg`, `--color-text`, `--color-muted`, `--color-accent`, `--color-ornament`, `--color-surface`) sit above the palette so a future dark or seasonal theme only remaps six lines.

## TYPE SCALE (FLUID, 360 → 1440PX)

| LEVEL          | CLASS                                       | FAMILY / WEIGHT                                                       | SIZE             | TRACKING |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|----------|
| Display H1     | <code>.display</code>                       | Cinzel 900, uppercase                                                 | 48 → 72px        | +0.15em  |
| Section H2     | <code>.section-title</code>                 | Bodoni Moda 600 (optical size auto)                                   | 32 → 40px        | +0.05em  |
| Subsection H3  | <code>.subhead</code>                       | Cinzel 400, uppercase                                                 | 20 → 24px        | +0.20em  |
| Body           | <code>body</code>                           | EB Garamond 400, old-style figures                                    | 16 → 18px / 1.65 | 0        |
| Caption / meta | <code>.caption</code><br><code>.meta</code> | Spectral italic 400                                                   | 13 → 14px        | +0.02em  |
| Eyebrow        | <code>.eyebrow</code>                       | Cinzel 400, uppercase, rust                                           | 12px             | +0.30em  |
| Drop cap       | <code>.dropcap</code>                       | Cinzel Decorative 700, rust; <b>initial-letter: 3</b> where supported | 3 lines          | —        |
| Greek          | <code>.hero__greek</code>                   | GFS Didot (Greek only), gold on ink                                   | 20 → 28px        | +0.08em  |

The reading column is capped at 62ch. Display type receives a negative right margin equal to its tracking so centred capitals are optically, not mathematically, centred.

## LAYOUT

- **Folio grid** — three columns: gloss margin (min 9rem), reading column (max 40rem), and a deliberately empty outer margin 1.6× wider. Padding is 5% left, 10% right on desktop, collapsing to max(16px, 6%) below 960px.
- **Sticky chapter** — caption column is `position: sticky; top: 18vh`; plates sit on a 6-column sub-grid with alternating offsets (1–5, 3–7, 1–7).
- **Stacked leaves** — each leaf is a 100svh sticky container; leaves 2 and 3 rest 1.25rem lower so the previous edge stays visible. On phones (<720px) stacking is switched off and leaves simply follow each other.
- **Contact sheet** — 12 columns with negative and positive margin offsets for an asymmetric, hand-laid feel; two columns on phones.

## MOTION

- Parallax writes a single custom property, `--py`, consumed by `transform: translate3d()`. Only transforms animate, so scrolling stays on the compositor.
- An IntersectionObserver keeps only on-screen layers in the update set; updates are batched in `requestAnimationFrame`. Native scrolling is never intercepted.
- Speeds are deliberately small: 0.02–0.12 for plates, 0.2–0.35 for backgrounds. Background layers are oversized (`inset: -12% / -25%`) so no edge can show.
- Text blocks fade up 1.5rem over 900ms on `cubic-bezier(.22, .61, .36, 1)`, once.
- `prefers-reduced-motion` disables parallax, reveal, the scroll cue and image zoom, and turns off smooth scrolling.

# 3 · Elegance review

Review of the pasted Hellenic Manuscript guide as a system for a fashion photography site, with what v1.0.1 already does about each point.

|                                           |        |
|-------------------------------------------|--------|
| Palette restraint & temperature           | 9 / 10 |
| Type pairing (display / section / body)   | 8 / 10 |
| Accessibility of the palette as specified | 6 / 10 |
| Spacing & manuscript proportion           | 9 / 10 |
| Economy (number of typefaces)             | 6 / 10 |
| Overall, as written                       | 8 / 10 |

## WHAT IS ALREADY ELEGANT

- **Warm, not white.** Ink on parchment gives 16.4:1 contrast without the glare of #000 on #FFF. Photography reads richer on a warm ground, and the parchment tint lets plates float.
- **The 60/30/10 split maps naturally onto a scroll page:** parchment for reading, ink for the three cinematic bands (hero, interlude, colophon), rust and gold only as points of light.
- **Lapidary capitals + Didone + Garamond** is a historically coherent trio: Roman inscription for titles, eighteenth-century high contrast for sections, Renaissance text face for reading.
- **Hairline gold at 40% opacity** is the right strength: it reads as ruling on a page, not as decoration.
- **Asymmetric margins** give the photographs room and stop the page from looking like a template.

## CONTRAST AUDIT (WCAG 2.2)

| FOREGROUND             | ON PARCHMENT      | ON AEGEAN INK               |
|------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------|
| Aegean Ink             | 16.37 <b>AAA</b>  | —                           |
| Amphora Rust           | 5.44 <b>AA</b>    | 3.01 <b>large text only</b> |
| Hellenic Gold          | 2.38 <b>fails</b> | 6.88 <b>AA</b>              |
| Laurel Leaf            | 6.08 <b>AA</b>    | 2.69 <b>fails</b>           |
| White on Rust (button) | 5.97 <b>AA</b>    |                             |

**The one real problem in the guide:** it assigns Hellenic Gold to “metadata”. On parchment, gold text is 2.38:1 and unreadable for many people. v1.0.1 resolves this by setting meta in Laurel on light grounds and allowing gold text only on Aegean Ink (`.meta--gold`, hero, colophon). Gold on parchment is used for rules only.

## REFINEMENTS RECOMMENDED FOR V1.1

1. **Fewer voices.** The guide calls on six families (Cinzel, Cinzel Decorative, Bodoni Moda, GFS Didot, EB Garamond, Spectral). EB Garamond’s own italic is one of the finest and could replace Spectral; Cinzel Decorative can be subset to the few drop-cap letters with Google Fonts’ `&text=` parameter. That cuts roughly a third of the font payload and tightens the page’s voice.
2. **“Thick, high-contrast” headers.** Cinzel is an inscriptional face with low stroke contrast; the high contrast lives in Bodoni Moda. The guide’s wording conflates the two. Consider Cinzel 700 instead of 900 for the hero: at 72px with +0.15em tracking, 900 starts to look heavy beside fine photography.

3. **Didone tracking.** +0.05em suits all-caps, but loosens lowercase Bodoni. For title-case H2s, +0.01–0.02em keeps the hairlines crisp. (This document already uses +0.02em for its H2s for comparison.)
4. **Thera White vs parchment.** Pure #FFF next to #F7F4EE can read slightly cool. Keep it for the stacked leaves, where the lift is intentional, but don't spread it to other surfaces.
5. **GFS Didot** should stay for Greek text only (as in the hero's Σύνοδος). For Latin H2s, Bodoni Moda has the better Latin glyphs and optical sizes.
6. **Rust on ink** (3.01:1) works for the colophon button, where white text sits on a rust fill, but never set rust text directly on ink below 24px.

## 4 • Production notes

### REPLACING THE PLACEHOLDER PHOTOGRAPHY

The demo uses `picsum.photos` seeded placeholders. Replace each `src` with your own plates, ideally as AVIF/WebP with `srcset`. Keep the hero at  $\geq 2000$ px wide and preload it. A light tonal filter (`saturate(.82) sepia(.12)`) pulls mixed sources toward the palette; remove it in `layout.css §1` if your grading is already final.

### ADDING A PARALLAX LAYER

```
<figure class="plate" data-speed="0.06">  positive = slower than scroll, negative = faster
  <div class="plate__frame"><img ...></div>
  <figcaption class="caption"><span class="caption__no">11</span> ...</figcaption>
</figure>
```

Background layers need headroom:  $\text{inset} \geq \text{speed} \times (\text{viewport} + \text{section height}) / 2$ .

### BROWSER SUPPORT

Evergreen Chromium, Firefox and Safari. `color-mix()`, `svh`, `text-wrap: balance` and `initial-letter` degrade gracefully: fallbacks are provided for viewport units and the drop cap, and balance is cosmetic.

### REBUILDING THIS PDF

```
sh docs/src/build-pdf.sh
```

### CHANGELOG

**1.0.1** — Gold restricted to dark grounds; interlude quote measure fixed; parallax measures each layer's own position; stacked leaves disabled on phones.

**1.0.0** — Initial single-scroll layout, tokens and parallax engine.